

Congress dear. The dilatory approach has given Telangana Rashtra Samithi President K. Chandrasekhara Rao the opportunity to bring his separate state campaign back to centre stage after it was lost in his party's drubbing in 2009 winning just a third (two Lok Sabha and 10 legislative Assembly seats) of what it had won in the 2004 polls. Now, the vexatious Telangana issue is a bugbear for the Congress with little hope of an early resolution notwithstanding even the appointment of the Justice B.N. Srikrishna Committee. Rosaiah is squarely putting the onus on Delhi rather than on the separatists, much like what YSR did. "As

chief minister I give equal importance to all regions and at the same time respect the feelings of every region. But unfortunately, the solution to this sensitive issue is not in my hands," he says.

In fact, he is limiting the perception of the campaign to a law and order issue. But the festering agitation, already at a high emotional pitch, is sending mixed signals to potential investors about growth prospects in Andhra Pradesh and Hyderabad in particular, which may, in the ultimate analysis, be part of Telangana if it is not carved out as a Union territory. Some critics argue that if Rosaiah had held his ground on

December 9, Home Minister P. Chidambaram would have desisted from making the statement in the manner in which it was phrased to create the impression of a fait accompli on a separate Telangana.

Yet, Rosaiah is addressing issues of governance, falling back on decades of administrative acumen as a minister well-versed in divergent problems facing the 23 districts and from the perspective of the Congress providing responsive governance. This is an uphill task because his moderate, placatory approach, as opposed to the domineering style of YSR, is construed as his singular weakness. But he is turning firm following the arrival of E.S.L. Narasimhan as governor, and the Central Government spelling out the terms of reference for the Srikrishna panel.

Narasimhan, a retired IAS officer of the Andhra Pradesh cadre who spent much of his career in the Intelligence Bureau from where he retired as director, is active in Raj Bhavan instead of treating it as a reclusive gubernatorial assignment. He keeps his ears to the ground to sense the social churning and other fallouts of the Telangana turmoil to be able to step in and call the shots in the event of turbulence.

Any other chief minister would have found this queer. Not Rosaiah. He is clear about the tasks cut out for him. Having opted out of the 2009 Assembly polls to get elected to the Legislative Council, skipping the demands of hectic electioneering, chief minister-ship has been thrust, along with the YSR legacy, on him. Therefore, he wants to acquit himself creditably, offering responsive governance to enable the Congress to do well in municipal elections this year and in those to Panchayati Raj institutions in 2011.

His task, however, is Herculean. Diverse factors, like the global recession, droughts, floods and political turmoil, have contributed to a revenue shortfall. The state is strapped for cash and cutbacks in flagship programmes, like the Jalayagnam irrigation mission and a host of welfare schemes initiated by YSR, are inevitable. Further, the flow of funds to Centrally sponsored schemes may not be on the scale that

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**ROSAIAH MAY  
BE THE CHOSEN  
ONE BUT LACKS  
CHARISMA  
AND DRIVE**